

Independent Research

Perception Audit — Goodspell

Internal document. Raw material. Not presented to the client. Conducted in two stages — the first before the discovery session, the second after.

Stage 1 — Surface Research

Conduct before the discovery session. Time limit: 45 minutes.

Purpose: Understand what the outside world sees before you speak to the client. Enter the session knowing what their public presence signals — not to form conclusions, but to ask better questions.

What to cover

- Website — What category does it place them in? What does the headline claim? What is missing from the first 10 seconds of reading?
- LinkedIn — Personal profile and company page if it exists. What do endorsements and recommendations reveal that the self-description doesn't?
- Any other public touchpoints — Press mentions, podcast appearances, published writing, social presence. What impression accumulates across all of them?

What to capture

One short paragraph — not a list. Write what impression forms if you know nothing about this person except what you just read. That paragraph goes into the discovery session as context, not as conclusion.

What not to do

Do not form a diagnosis yet. Do not decide where the gap is. Surface research tells you what to look for in the session — nothing more.

Stage 2 — Deep Research

Conduct after the discovery session and before writing the report.

Purpose: Now you know what the client told you — the tensions, the contradictions, the things they avoided. Use this to search with direction, not in general.

What to cover

- Category signals — How do competitors position themselves? What language does the market use? Where does the client's presence sit relative to others — above, below, or sideways?

- Specific gaps identified in the session — If the client mentioned a situation where their presence cost them an opportunity, look for the evidence of why.
- Involuntary associations — What category, level, or type of business does their presence align with intentionally or not? Who else looks like this?
- What the right clients would find — If the client's ideal client searched for them right now, what would they find? Would it make them more or less likely to reach out?

What to capture

Notes organized by what you found, not by where you looked. The source doesn't matter — the signal does.

What This Feeds

Stage 1 feeds the discovery session — specifically the questions in minutes 5–25 and 25–45.

Stage 2 feeds Section 1 and Section 3 of the Perception Gap Report — what the presence currently signals, and where the gap lives.

The report is written after Stage 2 is complete. Not before.